

Hashtable and Heap

Author: Eric Zhou

Email: eric_ds_zhou@outlook.com

Date: Oct 5, 2026

Introduction

This technical note summarizes the tools and logic used in Hashtable and heap.

Since we learned Two Sum with hash tables, why don't we take a look at the actual LeetCode Two Sum problem?

Question:

You are given an array of integers `nums` and an integer `target`, return indices of the two numbers such that they add up to `target`.

You may assume that each input would have exactly one solution, and you may not use the same element twice.

You can return the answer in any order.

Intuition

It's clear that for each element `A[i]`, we need to find its pair, `target - A[i]`.

The easiest way to solve this is to use two `for` loops to check all possible pairs in the array. However, the time complexity of this approach is $\Theta(n^2)$.

Therefore, we can use a hash table to improve the efficiency.

Approach

Since a well-implemented hash table supports dictionary operations such as `member`, `retrieve`, `add`, and `delete` in expected $\Theta(1)$ time, we can use a hash table to store the numbers we have already seen.

In Java, we use `containsKey()`, `get()`, and `put()` to perform these dictionary operations.

For each `nums[i]`, we first calculate:

$$need = target - nums[i]$$

Then, we check whether `need` is already in the hash table.

- If it is, we use `get()` to retrieve its index and return the two indices.
- Otherwise, we use `put()` to store `nums[i]` as the key and `i` as its value.

- Time complexity: $O(n)$

Code

```
class Solution {
    public int[] twoSum(int[] nums, int target) {
        HashMap<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();

        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            int need = target - nums[i];

            if (map.containsKey(need)) {
                return new int[]{map.get(need), i};
            }

            map.put(nums[i], i);
        }

        return new int[]{};
    }
}
```

Reference List

1. [*"CSE2331_Types_of_Probabilistic_Problems"*](#) Created by Professor Painter.
2. [*"Quick Sort Worksheet AU26"*](#) Created by Professor Painter.
3. [*"CSE2331_QuickSort_and_Probabilistic_Analysis_Homework"*](#) Created by Professor Painter.
4. LeetCode. ["1. Two Sum."](https://leetcode.com/problems/two-sum/) <https://leetcode.com/problems/two-sum/>